

Finland



A sparsely populated, forested country that has had an uneasy relationship with Russia.

1150s Finns convert to Christianity.

1323 **Treaty of Pähkinäsaari:** Finland part of Swedish kingdom.

1581 **Finland is made** a grand duchy under the Swedish crown.

1700–21 **Sweden is defeated** by Russia in the Great Northern War and is obliged to cede Finnish Karelia to Russia.

1809 **Treaty of Fredrikshamn:** Sweden cedes Finland to Russia. Finland becomes a grand duchy, enjoying autonomy.

1812 **Helsinki becomes** the capital.

1863 **Finnish becomes an** official language alongside Swedish.

1865 **Grand Duchy acquires** its own monetary system.

1879 **Conscription law lays** the foundation for a Finnish army.

1899 **Czar Nicholas II** begins process of russification. The Labor Party is founded.

1900 **Gradual imposition** of Russian as the official language.

1901 **Finnish army disbanded,** Finns ordered into Russian units. Disobedience campaign prevents men being drafted.

1903 **Labor Party becomes** Social Democratic Party (SDP).

1905 **National strike forces** restoration of 1899 status quo.

1906 **Universal** suffrage introduced.

1910 **Responsibility for important** legislation passed to Russian Duma.

1917 **Russian revolution allows** Finland to declare independence.

1918 **Civil war between** Bolsheviks and right-wing government. General Carl Gustav Mannerheim leads government to victory at Battle of Tampere.

1919 **Finland becomes a republic:** Kaarlo Ståhlberg elected president.

1920 **Treaty of Tartu:** USSR recognizes Finland's borders.

1921 **Åland Islands** become part of Finland.

1939 **Nazi-Soviet Pact** gives the USSR a free hand in Finland. A Soviet invasion of Finland is met with strong resistance.

1940 **Treaty of Moscow.** Finland cedes a tenth of its national territory.

1941 **Finnish troops join** Germany in its invasion of the USSR.

1944 **Red Army** invades and Finland, led by Marshal Mannerheim, signs armistice.

1946 **President Mannerheim** resigns; Juho Paasikivi president.

1948 **Friendship treaty** with the USSR: agrees to resist any attack on USSR made through Finland by Germany or its allies.

1952 **Payment of \$570** million in war reparations completed.

1956–91 **Coalition** governments between SDP and Agrarians hold power.

1989 **The USSR recognizes Finnish** neutrality for the first time.

1992 **Finland signs 10-year** agreement with Russia which, for first time since World War II, has no military provisions.

1995 **Finland joins** EU.

2000 **Tarja Halonen** is first woman head of state.

2002 **Finland adopts** the euro.

2008 **Former president Martti Ahtisaari** receives the 2008 Nobel Peace Prize.

«186–87 The Black Death

Estonia



The most northerly of the three Baltic states, and closely linked to Finland in language and culture.

1219 **Reval (now Tallinn)** is founded by Danish invaders, who convert the pagan Estonians. Sweden takes control 1561.

1721 **By the Treaty** of Nystadt, Russia acquires Estonia from Sweden, under whose rule Estonia has become Lutheran.

1881 **A policy of** russification in public life, including the construction of an Orthodox cathedral in Tallinn in 1900, strengthens national consciousness.

1917 **The Russian provisional** government allows the creation of a unified Estonian district and elections to an Estonian National Council. The council moves to secede from Russia after the October Revolution when a Bolshevik government is imposed. Declares independence February 1918.



Historic Tallinn

This ancient city has always been an important center for Baltic Sea trade. During the 13th century it was the northernmost member of the Hanseatic League, the mercantile alliance of trading cities.

1919 **Assisted by the** British fleet and Finnish volunteers Estonia forces the Red Army out of the country; independence is confirmed by the Treaty of Tartu in 1920.

1934–38 **President Paets** declares a state of emergency and rules by decree.

1940 **Soviet forces annex** Estonia.

1941–44 **Germany occupies** Estonia.

1944 **Thousands of Estonians** fight with the Finns against Soviet forces.

1949 **Soviet leader Stalin** deports 95,000 Estonians to labor camps as the country is reabsorbed into the USSR.

1985 **Reform in the USSR** is not matched by hardliners in Estonian Supreme Soviet.

1988 **The Estonian Supreme Soviet** declares sovereignty.

1989 **Estonian made** official language.

1990 **Elections to the** Estonian Supreme Soviet result in a nationalist majority. Independence is declared in 1991.

1992 **First multi-party** elections.

1994 **Last Soviet troops** withdraw.

2004 **Estonia joins** the EU and NATO.

2007 **Rift with Russia** over the removal of a Russian war memorial from Tallinn.

Latvia



A Baltic nation with sizeable Russian and other minority populations.

1237 **The Swordbrothers and** Teutonic knights merge (as the Livonian Order) after the territory of modern-day Latvia is subjugated by Germans.

1558 **Russia declares** war on the Livonian Order over access to the Baltic, capturing 20 Livonian strongholds (but renounces its claim in 1582).

1609 **Livonia is ceded** to Sweden by Vasili IV Shuisky of Russia in return for troops during the Russian Time of Troubles.

1721 **Russia acquires Livonia** and Estonia from Sweden under Treaty of Nystadt.

1773 **On the second** partition of Poland, the Polish part of current-day Latvia becomes part of the Russian Empire.

1917 **Opposes Russian Bolshevik** Revolution. Declares independence.

1918–20 **Invaded by Bolsheviks** and German forces.

1920 **Latvian independence** recognized by Russia.

1940 **Incorporated into USSR** under the Nazi-Soviet Pact.

1990 **Popular Front of Latvia (PLF)** wins elections and declares independence from the USSR.

1991 **USSR recognizes** independence.

1998 **Naturalization** procedure is eased to help the Russian and other minorities gain Latvian citizenship.

1998–2002 **Political instability** with four different prime ministers.

1999 **Vaira Vik-Freiberga** becomes the first woman president. The last Russian military installation in Latvia—the Skrunda radar station—is dismantled.

2000 **Latvian proclaimed** the only state language, and is used in all schools from 2004. This strains relations with Russia.

2004 **Latvia joins** the EU and NATO. Latvia elects Indulis Emsis as the world's first Green prime minister.

2007 **Latvia signs** a border demarcation treaty with Russia.

FINNISH WAR LEADER (1867–1951)

MARSHAL MANNERHEIM

Baron Carl Gustav Emil Mannerheim was a Finnish field marshal. Born into a noble Swedish-Finnish family, Mannerheim rose to the rank of general in the czarist army of Russian-occupied Finland. In 1918 he led his forces against the Finnish Bolsheviks, and in the following year became regent of Finland. Defeated in the elections of 1919, he retired and became a philanthropist. But in 1931 he returned to the fore as head of the Finnish defense council and commanded the Finnish forces against the USSR in the Winter War of 1939–40 and again in 1941–44. In August 1944 he became president and ended the war with the USSR. Ill health drove him to resign in 1946.

